

Define the problem

Start with one operational problem. Complete this workbook with the process owner, a budget holder and people doing the work. It supports a decision; it is not a quote or a recommendation to build.

Problem and owner

Which task is difficult, who experiences it, and who can make decisions about it?

Evidence and desired outcome

Record a normal period, task volume, active work and waiting time. Label estimates. What change would be useful?

Current workflow and options

List tools, handoffs and exceptions. What configuration or integration options have you tested?

Illustrative charity example: referrals arrive in a shared inbox, are reviewed, then copied to an assignment register. Start with that handoff, not a replacement for every system.

Scope guidance: faithfulsoftware.dev/guides/custom-software-cost-uk

Next steps: faithfulsoftware.dev/resources/software-investment-framework

People, records and access

Describe record types and use fictional examples. Do not include real beneficiary, safeguarding, donor or payment records in an initial supplier brief.

People and responsibilities

Who submits, reviews, approves and supports the work? Include occasional volunteers and people needing assistance.

Records and boundaries

Which role may view, change or export which records? Who grants access and removes it when someone leaves?

Systems and dependencies

Which systems hold the source records? Who owns exports, integration access and cleanup? What is still unknown?

Illustrative church example: test registration with fictional households. Check who may see each record, how errors are corrected and how an administrator helps someone who cannot use the portal.

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Agree the first release

Define tasks that users can demonstrate, including exceptions. Keep launch essentials separate from later ideas so suppliers can assess the same work.

Essential tasks and exclusions

What must work at launch? What can wait? Name the person who decides whether a new request belongs in scope.

Acceptance and recovery

Write three tasks with an expected result. Include a failed submission, restricted access or an unavailable source.

Migration and adoption

Who checks imported records, trains staff and supports assisted routes? How will work continue during a problem?

Example acceptance task: an authorised coordinator can assign a request, see its next action and find its history. Record how you will test it; do not assume a screen design proves it works.

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Make the next decision

Mark each area Ready, Needs evidence or Blocked. Do not turn this into a percentage. A serious unresolved dependency should remain visible.

Budget and constraints

Separate discovery, delivery, migration and training from hosting, licences, maintenance and support. State assumptions.

Ongoing owner and exit

Who operates the system after launch? Who controls accounts, backups and the code? What would a handover require?

Open question / owner / next action

Record the largest uncertainty, who will resolve it and what evidence would change the preferred option.

Next: compare configuration, integration and bespoke work using the Software Investment Framework. Ask a supplier to scope the next decision and state assumptions before committing to a full build.

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